

ANIL DAYAL



JASWANT ADDRESSES THE MEDIA SHORTLY AFTER HIS EXPULSION FROM THE BJP

THE INTERNAL REPORT ON THE LOK SABHA ELECTIONS BLAMES THE LACK OF UNITY AMONG THE TOP LEADERSHIP AS ONE OF THE MAIN REASONS FOR THE PARTY'S DEBACLE.

was worse. Jaswant, a founder member of the BJP in 1980 and among its seniormost leaders, was told that the party's parliamentary board, which met earlier in the day, had expelled him from the party and his primary membership stood withdrawn. "I regret the manner in which I was informed. They should have told me in person. I would have liked the courtesy of having been told personally by Advaniji and Rajnathji that I have been expelled," Jaswant told reporters shortly after he received the news. The expression on his face was one of shock. It needn't have been so had he just read the writing on the walls of the Nehru Memorial auditorium on August 17 where his latest book—*Jinnah: India-Partition-Independence*—was released. Not a single BJP leader was present. Arun Shourie, his former cabinet colleague who was to be part of a panel discussion during the book

launch, cried off at the last minute, taking the plea that his crowded schedule did not permit him to fully read and digest the book in time for the occasion. If Jaswant's isolation was gradual, his expulsion two days later was swift.

It is the worst of times for the BJP. In the past, senior leaders like Madan Lal Khurana and Uma Bharati have been suspended or have walked out of the party, but never in its 29 years has the BJP expelled a leader as senior in the hierarchy as Jaswant. But grim situations don't warrant courteous gestures. Electorally, the party is at its lowest ebb, having lost back-to-back elections to the Lok Sabha, and its numbers are down to what they were a little less than two decades ago. Dissent, once mild, now grips the party and boat rockers ply their trade from top to bottom. In the meantime, the Congress-led UPA is marching in unison.